much do you owe on these cards?" she again demanded. He didn't have the answer to that question either.

Susie then proceeded to go through Sam's credit card statements as they arrived in the mail and added up the damage. By the time she had calculated the total, it was a shocking $40,000. This is a lot of debt for someone who is only twenty-three years old. She discovered his designer suits, dinners out, imported flowers, and even his trip to Paris had all been charged. Sam must have been very dedicated to spending to accumulate that much debt in such a short time. Susie had always admired Sam for his tenacity to get what he wanted. In this case, he must have wanted debt badly.

In fact, it wasn't debt that Sam wanted, but it came along as a consequence to what he really wanted, which was to be rich. He had received his first credit card in college and suddenly found it to be a way to overcome his feelings of being deprived. He had been raised in a very poor family. He was on an academic scholarship at Yale, where the education of most of the students was funded by their parents, or so he assumed. With credit cards, he now had a way to fit in. He could buy expensive clothes, treat his friends to dinner, and join them on weekend excursions.

In spite of his debt, Susie decided to marry Sam. It took the two of them about five years and a dramatic lifestyle change to pay off his debt. Even after they were debt free, Susie continued to harbor a grudge that since her hard earned money was being spent to help reduce Sam's debt, it could not be used for other things like paying off her student loan debt sooner or saving for a house. She resented not having a say over where they allocated their earnings.

This issue of debt being brought into a marriage has been shown to be a primary problem area for newlyweds, according to the Center for Marriage and Family. As couples struggle